Name: Jack Flat Date:

002A.3 — Wednesday October 7 — Italian Humanism and Classical Revival

DO NOW — Name one fourteenth-century crisis and one effect.

THE ITALIAN RENAISSANCE ITSELF

READING — Florence, classical revival, and the meaning of "rebirth"

1. The word "Renaissance" means "rebirth" in French, and it is used to describe a great period of European cultural development beginning in the late 14th century.

2. The Renaissance was centered around Florence, a city-state in central Italy dominated by the Medici family for much of the fifteenth century. (Italy was comprised of a handful of small states~ Florence, Milan, Naples, Piedmont, the Papal States; the Kingdom of Italy was proclaimed in 1861.) The Renaissance began in the late 14th -century and 15th-century Italy, on the northern half of the Italian peninsula, the region that contained Europe's greatest cities and towns, and its most vibrant commercial trade. Its merchants and artisans were key to producing not only crafts, but also the love of beauty and great art. (These would later be depicted in Shakespeare's The Merchant of Venice.) The artisans devoted their work to creating not only useful, but beautiful things. Many of them were patronized by the region's merchants who supported religion and the arts.

3. Renaissance culture looked back to the Greeks and Romans for inspiration, and that's why it's described as a "rebirth" - it brought back Greek and Roman thought to the forefront of Italian / Florentine culture. Again, the ancients had been largely replaced by medieval developments like Gothic architecture, which emerged around Paris in the mid-twelfth century and spread across Europe.

4. Of course, Greek culture had been respected and developed in Western Europe for a while:

   A. Through Latin translations,

   B. Through Roman works that referred to it,

   C. Through Latin translations of Arabic translations,

   D. Through Latin translations arising from Greek intellectuals and texts that had been absorbed from the Eastern Roman Empire (Byzantine Empire) after its takeover by a Latin crusader kingdom.

5. And that can lead us to ask the question: Was the Renaissance really a "re-birth?" Many historians think that the answer is "no," viewing it merely as a continuation of the intellectual developments that had already been evolving in the "Middle Ages."

   A. But Renaissance figures saw themselves as reviving an old Greco-Roman tradition after many of its texts had been forgotten or cast aside.

   B. Renaissance scholars revived ancient texts and developed new ideas from them. Both revival and change shaped the period.

C. The Renaissance created a culture inspired by, but yet radically different from, the Greco-Roman world. It was heavily influenced by the Hebrew Bible and Christianity, and therefore looked back at the Greco-Roman world through a new lens. Just like the Greeks and Romans, Renaissance artists and scholars were interested in the majesty of man and what human beings are capable of doing. But they added a spiritual significance to this focus.

i. For example, when it came to painting the scene of the Akeidah (the binding of Isaac), Renaissance and post-Renaissance artists like Caravaggio and Rembrandt mixed an emotional and very realistic human portrayal of the story with a sense of spiritual significance. Earlier devotional images could emphasize sacred meaning over bodily naturalism; medieval styles varied, and this is not a universal contrast.

6. Medieval developments had produced much of the foundation for the religious and scientific thought that would advance in the Renaissance and in the Modern Era after it. But the Middle Ages had focused on religion and the afterlife.

7. Medieval Christian thought placed great weight on salvation and the afterlife. Renaissance humanists gave added prestige to civic action, education, and human accomplishment; Christian belief and practice remained central.

8. For example, the Renaissance emphasized beauty in secular life, putting more emphasis than the Middle Ages on decorating homes (as opposed to churches).

CUE / TOPIC	**YOUR NOTES**
Time + center — *when / where?*	
Florence — *merchants, artisans, patrons*	
Worldly beauty — *what expands beyond churches?*	

MAP — Italy about 1494

Find Florence. Name two other states shown on the map.



MAJOR TRENDS AND CHANGES IN THE RENAISSANCE

RETRIEVAL CHECK — From Unit 001 and Dante, recall one example of medieval concern with salvation, religious practice, or Church authority. Keep that example in mind while you compare the Renaissance trends below.

READING — Political thought, education, and the Renaissance individual

2. Politics:

A. The era reintroduced Cicero and the classics, with their emphasis on human leadership.

B. For a long time, medieval political theory had been concerned with the proper regime and natural law.

i. Natural law says there is a specific order to the world, and people should maintain that order. One of the ways we do that, it argues, is by applying our natural reason to determine what is right. We can figure out what makes for good law by thinking through what is good for people.

C. But during the Renaissance, there was a renewed interest in good individual leaders and their abilities, as opposed to abstract ways of determining how a society should be run according to laws.

D. There was a new twist, though. Unlike Greeks and Romans, who emphasized the importance of particular virtues that were seen as necessary for a leader, the Renaissance emphasized the notion that individual leaders could be uniquely great—not just that they could have good virtues necessary for a leader, but that people could be uniquely important.

E. Think about the titles of the books. Plato's book is the Republic, and Aristotle's book is the Politics. These are very abstract and theoretical. But Machiavelli named his book the Prince. So, even the different titles point to the difference. Machiavelli is thinking about a real-world leader.

10. Education became more orderly, with secondary schools before university that divided students into levels. There was a renewed interest in Greek, and Latin was now learned with a greater focus on the ancient classical texts, instead of simply the Latin translation of the Bible (called the Vulgate) and later medieval works.

11. Courtesy: Courtly conduct and manners were important before the Renaissance and continued to develop. Castiglione's Book of the Courtier made cultivated conduct, conversation, and accomplishment central to its ideal courtier. It is evidence of a particular ideal of social formation, not proof that medieval people had no manners.

CONTINUITY CHECK — Name one medieval Christian institution or practice that remains important in Renaissance Italy while art, education, politics, or views of human possibility change:

CUE / TOPIC	YOUR NOTES
Religion / emphasis — afterlife + ascetic ideals continue ↔ expanded attention to human potential, worldly beauty, active/civic life	
Politics — regime + natural law ↔ particular leader + real city	
Painting — symbolic / inverse perspective ↔ linear perspective / human viewpoint	
Sculpture — church setting / symbolic form ↔ freestanding body / motion / anatomy	
Architecture — Gothic / vertical / church ↔ classical forms + civic space	
Literature / humanism — humane letters + human experience	
Neo-Platonism / human action — why this world matters	
General → particular / exceptional individuals	
Education — Greek / classical Latin / formation of the person	
Courtesy — court manners / self-control / social distinction	

D. Literature: The era of humanism - a focus on human potential and accomplishments - was born at the end of the Middle Ages, with writers like Petrarch, and at the beginning of the Renaissance. Humanism centered on classical languages and humane letters as a means of forming the cultivated person. Many humanists were Christians; Erasmus exemplifies Christian humanism in the Northern Renaissance. This is a shift in educational emphasis, not proof that medieval thinkers denied individuality.

i. Writing now focused on the human experience - the concept of "humane letters" was emphasized in education. Education was supposed to make a person humane, giving them the ability to live the most human life possible, one full of culture and liberty.

a. This included a return to classical Latin, which was preferred over ecclesiastical (church) Latin because of its style and worldliness. (Today, since we don't speak Latin, it's hard to appreciate the difference. But to them, there was a big difference. The Latin of the Middle Ages was often overly technical and boring, while the Latin of Cicero and Livy was lively. Italian humanists knew Latin and often learned Greek.)

b. But the Renaissance also differed from the Middle Ages in the other direction. Along with going backwards when it came to Latin (to something that seemed more authentic), it moved forward when it came to the vernacular. Other languages, like Florentine Italian, the type of Italian spoken in the city of Florence, had started to become important starting in the Middle Ages, and the Renaissance accelerated this trend. Over a long period of time, national languages would form. For instance, Florentine Italian became the dominant form of Italian across Italy, as different Italian dialects were consolidated into one formal language. English and French would soon do the same thing, each become a distinct language. (Although even today, there are some differences within the languages. In Italy, the differences are so significant that it can be hard for people to understand each other. The same thing is true with the "German" spoken in Germany, Austria, and Switzerland.)

Primary source — Human work and nature

MIDRASH TANCHUMA, TAZRIA 5

It once happened that the evil Turnus Rufus asked Rabbi Akiva, "Which are the greater works, those of the Holy One Blessed is He or those of flesh and blood?" He said to him, "Those of flesh and blood are greater." Turnus Rufus said, "But the Heavens and Earth - is Man able to make such as those?" Rabbi Akiva said to him, "Don't speak to me about something which is beyond Man, which he has no mastery over, rather speak of things which are found among people." He said, "Why do you circumcise?" He replied, "I knew you were going to ask me about that, which is why I started by telling you that the works of Man are better than the works of the Holy One Blessed is He." Rabbi Akiva brought him stalks [of grain] and loaves [of bread]. He said to him, "These are the works of the Holy One Blessed is He, and these are the works of Man." He said, "Aren't these better than the stalks?!"

SOURCE CONNECTION — In the grain/loaf example, what role does human action play? Note the exact contrast in 5–10 words:

human action is the bread, grain is God's action. Bread tastes better than grain.

Palmer & Colton Reading and Evidence Questions

II. The Italian Renaissance — P&C pp. 53–61

5. A new conception of life. On pp. 53–55, what changes in outlook lead Palmer & Colton to call the Renaissance a new era in "thought and feeling"? Give two specific contrasts with the medieval outlook described there.

Renaissance allowed for enjoyment of wealth, used beautiful things which was the opp. of Medieval darkness & self denial. Renaissance praised [illegible] & Fame. While medizval was more solo Meditate

6. Humanism. Why do Palmer & Colton call the literary movement "humanism"? Use one detail about what humanists read and one detail about what they tried to do with writing.

bc humanism focused on nature, experience & good manners more than just church teachings.

8. Bruni and civic humanism. How did Leonardo Bruni use ancient learning for a present political purpose in Florence? Answer from the discussion on pp. 58–60.

Bruni wrote a history of Florence to inspire the locals. He showed that effective Romans to speak & write well + worthwhile skill to influence public polit & govt.

WRITING PRACTICE — Choose Question 5 or 8. Draft a topic sentence that makes a claim, then list three note-form details from the assigned pages that actually support that claim.

humanists rejected religion and turned to ancient religions texts.

HOMEWORK — for Thursday 10/08: Read Palmer & Colton pp. 62–70 (9 pages), using 002C1. Mark one Northern Renaissance development and one New Monarchy/state-building development. Bring 002B and 002C.1.